Introduction

This paper examines the multimodal presentation artifact "White Cube As a Mode of Presentation." The white cube, often associated with hierarchical and exclusive museums, is frequently perceived to rely excessively on specialized knowledge, creating high entry barriers and making it difficult for people to participate in discussions (Trofanenko and Segall, 2014). This artifact aims to demystify the white cube discourse, thus enhancing broader engagement. As a mediator, I render this concept accessible to my model reader(audience)—high school students interested in art but lacking formal art-related education, ideally with some exhibition experience. When introducing the "white cube" debate, I draw upon foundational knowledge from five common high school subjects. This knowledge that both the audience and I have learned acts as both common communicative code and context that play crucial role in communication. Therefore, the importance of this background knowledge is stated at the beginning for viewer discretion.

I envision this artifact as an educational tool for classroom use beyond social media, such as YouTube. The presentation balances professionalism and entertainment by strategically combining sensory elements like tone, imagery, and sound effects. I made this artifact a balanced and organic whole by employing various sensory inputs and communication strategies. Although it aims to facilitate individual reflection, through careful consideration and refinement, the artifact is ultimately designed to communicate my intentions.

This reflective essay explores how various theories, including Dewey's effective communication, Eco's model and empirical readers, open and closed texts, Schön's reflexive and rational models, and Jakobson's functions of language, simultaneously guide the creation of the artifact through nuanced and continuous balancing.

Consider the Artifact as Multimodal

As an exhibition space, the white cube is a medium for communication and public education, facilitating the dissemination of knowledge and the formation of perspectives (Trofanenko and Segall, 2014). It also demonstrates strong multimodality characteristics. Multimodality is a communication approach that directs the addresser to engage all available modes of communication (Kress, 2010). In my preparatory process, I envisioned myself as a curator selecting and configuring modes, employing various strategies, and assembling them appropriately to engage the audience best. Increased sensory engagement makes abstract concepts more concrete and encourages unique interpretations (Jewitt, 2011; Kress, 2010). For instance, around the third minute, muting the background noise highlights the "undisturbed" nature of the white cube through auditory cues. In a multimodal context, assemblages provide a theoretical foundation and emphasize both the independence and interaction of sensory components. As a pedagogical assemblage, it serves as a site of knowledge creation, where diverse semiotic systems and communication elements converge to collectively forge the audience's subjective perceptions. (Simon, 1992). The visual design serves two purposes: to present essential information while maximizing aesthetics clearly. In other words, under the premise of not compromising the clarity of the information conveyed, assemble an exquisite and aesthetic impression. Additionally, charming explanatory illustrations, paired with playful sound effects, mitigate the potential monotony of the presentation, making it suitable for teenage audiences.

Key terms are highlighted with vivid colors, using visually striking images to fill the entire screen in crucial sections. Secondary information is subtly incorporated within the slides, maintaining a balance between foregrounding primary content and offering possibilities for further exploration. Subtitles, while potentially distracting, are essential for reaching a wider audience, including those with hearing impairments. As with exhibitions, this artifact's dominant modes of communication are visual and auditory, yet the mode of display is critical for interpretation and engagement (Trofanenko and Segall, 2014). All elements' arrangement and timing were meticulously planned and tested. I withdraw a straightforward catalog to avoid over-stratifying the content due to assumption-laden mapping (Lowe and Brotton, 2017). Exaggerated transition animations address the lack of precise segmentation, such as the shift from white cube’s basic concepts to related debate at 8:27.

Effective Communication: The Subtle Collaboration between Models, Texts, and

Readers

This artifact is crafted to enable audiences to generate personal interpretations, aligning Dewey's (1916) emphasis on communication as a critical societal function and transmitting insightful ideas across generations. Outlining the expectation of the creator and the potential rewards of watching the video positions the audience as full-fledged model readers who actively interpret the author's intentions and develop their stance in discussions (Pisanty, 2015). Effective communication requires common understanding and like-mindedness. To achieve this, Schön's (1988) rational and reflective models guide different sections of the artifact, each tailored to specific communication aims. Besides, the text uses language that resonates with the audience to ensure communicative effectiveness (Eco, 1979). Establishing a model audience that understands the artifact's nuances and layered meanings is crucial for developing communication strategies.

A predictable, repetitive, closed text lays a comprehensive and objective knowledge base to ensure all audiences share a common understanding before moving to subjective interpretations. This approach, grounded in the rational model, highlights truthfulness and maximizes language's referential function. For example, introducing the white cube concept with screenshots of O'Doherty's (1976) original article enhances credibility. This phase uses real-world images, direct quotes, research articles, and expert opinions to form a factual concept of the white cube without seeking personal interpretations.

Building on this foundation, Schön's (1988) reflective model instructs in stimulating independent thinking and broad awareness. Unlike the rational model's linear information flow aimed at preventing distortion, the reflective model views communication as a two-way process, accommodating the audience's perspectives, biases, and interests while allowing the creative application of knowledge.

Moreover, it is the empirical reader, not the idealized model reader, who interprets the text. To accommodate the disparity, I switch from closed text to open text, which rejects definitive and concluded messages. Open text greatly values viewers' creative interpretations and their unique encyclopedic knowledge (Eco,1989; Guillemette & Cossette, 2006). This model also emphasizes the interplay of elements, enhancing the multimodal nature of the presentation and letting the audience bring their contexts to their interaction with the artifact. As the social climate and discourse continuously evolve, it is challenging for creators to grasp shifting realities fully (Francese, 2003).

Nonetheless, the indeterminate zone of this artifact acknowledges and adapts indeterminacy (Schön, 1988). Empirical readers, as described by Eco (1979), "make sense" of texts by filtering them through their cognitive and encyclopedic structures (Pisanty, 2015), resulting in diverse reactions that may not align perfectly with the author's intended paths. This diversity fulfills the open texts and accomplishes multiple or mediated interpretations. The audience's understanding of the metaphors, individually or collectively, depends highly on their interpretative context.

Despite this openness, the creating process inherently guides interpretations towards the pre-established way to realize foreseen communicative results. Although the result empowers audiences to form individual standpoints (Schön, 1988), it is eventually pedagogical guidance toward my intentions- a typical result of closed texts (Eco, 1979). Eco (1989) argues that a genuinely open text should let audiences interpret freely without external influences. Although this artifact avoids a didactic tone, it offers clear interpretive paths. Instead, in this case, the openness itself is what Eco (1989, p. 4) calls the never impinged 'unalterable specificity.'

Lastly, Eco(1993) notes that reshaping information is common when engaging with texts. To manage deformation or overinterpretations, establishing a range of acceptable interpretations is essential (Guillemette & Cossette, 2006). As mentioned before, in this artifact, full-fledged model readers who grasp the creator's intent are more likely to correct interpretations by adapting their horizon of expectation to the text (Eco, 1994; Francese, 2003). This awareness, combined with the close text upfront and using illustrations and metaphors, retains the ability to interpret content within a controlled yet open framework.

Recontextualization: Using Metaphors to Bridge Knowledge Gaps

Dowling (2020) describes recontextualization as transforming texts and practices when they are moved between different contexts of reading or enactment. In presenting the complex and abstract concept of the white cube, I used a series of metaphors to assist audiences in grasping new, elusive information through familiar concepts. These metaphors not only stimulate reflective thinking, aiding long-term memory but also illuminate the intricate nature of this discussion, encouraging diverse contributions to its discussion. Through the lens of assemblages, each metaphor strategically contributes to the audience's holistic understanding of the concept. Continuous exposure to these metaphors even facilitates corrective interaction among understandings toward each metaphor, thereby increasing the depth and effectiveness of communication.

In educating high school students about the white cube, I rely on a "communal high school knowledge cupboard" of shared signs and symbols to construct meanings (Cobley, 2005). By tapping into their existing knowledge in familiar domains, I make new concepts in new domains accessible. The idea of a vacuum in physics, devoid of matter and sets the stage for ideal gases, serves as a prerequisite for understanding this part and justifies the choice of this metaphor. This knowledge is included in the physics syllabus. To ensure the explanations used during recontextualization align with the knowledge base of model readers, I consulted nine high school students from various countries. By fully understanding the audience's level of knowledge, I selected the most appropriate method of recontextualization (referential function). Given the artifact's long-term online availability, I choose time-tested metaphors. While I can't ensure that the empirical audience will access the information from my knowledge base used in creating the artifact, it should at least be currently accessible to my model reader. In addition to adjusting language based on the model reader's encyclopedia, all presentation elements follow this principle. An artwork is needed as a reference point in the coordinating system metaphor to encourage reflection on the white cube's significance as an exhibition form. Contemporary artworks are suitable but may not be easily recognized due to lower popularity. Therefore, I use the more recognizable Mona Lisa as a substitute.

However, metaphors can be double-edged swords (Chen, 2012). They emphasize similarities and may obscure differences. Despite their universal applicability, the arbitrariness of language persists. In recontextualization, where knowledge is inherently value-laden, conveying knowledge in a value-neutral manner often proves challenging (Schön, 1988). All communicative acts are shaped by their creators' interests and motivations in specific contexts (Bezemer, 2012), and audience comprehension is further complicated by cultural, social, and historical factors, making control increasingly difficult. In creating this artifact, I guide the audience toward developing an understanding similar to my own—a reevaluation of social norms. During the creation phase, as a social science student, my extensive engagement with social science literature and feminism heightened my sensitivity to these norms. My understanding of the white cube as a social norm is built on my accumulated experiences, including my resentment, reflections, and discussions on societal norms. High school students who have not majored in social sciences might find it challenging to empathize due to their lack of related experiences in their encyclopedia. Even if all the items appearing in the artist are there.

Throughout my learning creation phases, recontextualization occurred twice. My preparation involved a reading list and class notes from my friend Elaine, an art history major. Through my studies, I realized that deeper discussions involving terms like institutionalism, public art, museology (Bishop, 2013), and capitalist museum (Krauss, 1990). Although unfamiliar with these concepts, by focusing on social norms, I saw parallels between social science debates on class, gender binary, racial segregation, and art discussions. Conversations with Elaine often bridged these fields, assisting my understanding. When I finished all the readings, I asked Elaine, "The white cube itself is a Synecdoche, right? It condenses (...) representing a wider debate?" Having chosen a linguistic module with 'Synecdoche' included in her encyclopedia, Elaine quickly comprehended and confirmed my understanding.

Nevertheless, I also considered how the differences between Elaine, the model reader of her literature and lectures, and me, the empirical reader, the difference might affect my thoughts. Obviously, our art related encyclopedia does not entirely match. Based on this consideration, the core of the artifact is to expose the complexity of the white cube discussion, fostering awareness and inquiry rather than delving into professional justifications. This choice tactfully avoids the potential distortion of knowledge that could occur if presented too simplistically. Moreover, when explaining the abstract concept of the white cube using language alone, it is challenging for the audience to grasp the concept intuitively. Guided by multimodality, I employ illustrations, motion effects, real-world scenes, and audio to recontextualize or, in other words, visualize the explanations.

Leveraging Language Functions to Communicate

In my presentation, I consistently harness language functions, using various speech techniques like animations, sound effects, questions, and tonal modulation to align the speaker and audience emotionally and intellectually, thereby maintaining effective communication (Dewey, 1916; Jakobson, 1960).

Throughout the presentation, I maintain high enthusiasm. When encouraging the audience's participation, I emphasize my tone and use the first person to convey attitudes and emotions (emotive function). For instance, I share a personal anecdote about an awkward moment at the Tate that helped me relate to those who had similar experiences. Acknowledging the content's complexity ("I know this is complex…") not only expresses my respect for the audience's earnest engagement (emotive function) but also stimulates further participation (phatic function).

Transitional phrases summarizing previous content and introducing new sections, like "We've explored... now let us...", focus the audience's attention (conative function), help them follow the speech's main thread (Referential Function), and ensure communication channels remain open (phatic function). Multifunctionality of language also occurs in phrases designed to resonate with the audience（emotive function）, such as "I bet most of you have seen…" and rhetorical questions, which ensure the audience's interest or involvement in upcoming discussions (phatic function), while influencing their behavior by encouraging them to recall, imagine, or share their perspectives on the white cube (conative function). More explicit cognitive functions emerge through the four countdowns and guiding words, maintaining presentation flow. Phrases like "regard...as..." guide the audience to grasp concepts more deeply through comparisons between the referent and the metaphor.

Since high school students are not art experts, I simplify standardized technical terms and definitions to match their knowledge base (referential function), supplemented by continuous checks(e.g., "Is everyone still with me?") to ensure accurate understanding (Metalinguistic Function). In fact, the previously mentioned phrase "We've explored…" also serves this function as it summarizes previous content and allows the audience to confirm their understanding.

Conclusion

In Dewey's (1916) view of socialization, communication is fundamental. Beyond acquiring the concept of the white cube, engaging in its discourse, and questioning any socially constructed paradigms, the goal of the artifact is to translate students' reflections during the presentation into character development and nurture a habit of critical thinking. This transformative experience prominently enlightens individuals (Dewey, 1916). For society, it exemplifies how knowledge, culture, and thought patterns are transmitted across generations, embodying "the greatest of human goods" (Dewey, 1925). As a presentation mode, different audiences respond differently towards artworks exhibited in a white cube; as an idea in my video, different audiences reflect differently towards a white cube. As a knowledge-producing artifact, this video is a collaborative assembly of humans (myself and the audience) and material elements (all items in the artifact), each element contributing to a dynamic, unique, and ultimately unpredictable communicative outcome.

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